The Jungle

Upton Sinclair · 1906 · excerpts from Chapter 9 / Chapter 14

Source: Upton Sinclair, The Jungle (1906), text via Project Gutenberg (#140). Public domain.

Upton Sinclair spent seven weeks undercover in the Chicago meatpacking plants in 1904 and produced this novel about Lithuanian immigrant Jurgis Rudkus. Sinclair intended the book as socialist propaganda — an exposé of industrial labor. What captured the public instead were the descriptions of unsanitary meat production. Within months of publication, Congress passed the Pure Food and Drug Act and the Meat Inspection Act (both 1906). Sinclair famously said: 'I aimed at the public's heart, and by accident I hit it in the stomach.'

Connect: Sinclair wanted to expose worker abuse but changed food-safety law instead. What does that reveal about Progressive-era priorities compared with Gilded Age labor movements (Class 30)?

Key Passages

On the workforce

> Of the butchers and floorsmen, the beef-boners and trimmers, and all those who used knives, you could scarcely find a person who had the use of his thumb; time and time again the base of it had been slashed, till it was a mere lump of flesh against which the man pressed the knife to hold it. The hands of these men would be criss-crossed with cuts, until you could no longer pretend to count them or to trace them.

On the lard tanks

> their peculiar trouble was that they fell into the vats; and when they were fished out, there was never enough of them left to be worth exhibiting,—sometimes they would be overlooked for days, till all but the bones of them had gone out to the world as Durham's Pure Leaf Lard!

On 'potted ham'

> It was only when the whole ham was spoiled that it came into the department of Elzbieta. Cut up by the two-thousand-revolutions-a-minute flyers, and mixed with half a ton of other meat, no odor that ever was in a ham could make any difference. … These rats were nuisances, and the packers would put poisoned bread out for them; they would die, and then rats, bread, and meat would go into the hoppers together. This is no fairy story and no joke

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	Progressive Era: rapid industrialization, immigrant labor in urban factories, and muckraking journalism exposing corruption and corporate abuses.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Middle-class American readers, especially reformers and consumers; it first ran in the socialist newspaper Appeal to Reason.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Upton Sinclair, a socialist and muckraking writer, who sympathized with immigrant workers and wanted to expose industrial capitalism.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ — explain similarities OR differences: Compare The Jungle's impact with that of Uncle Tom's Cabin a half-century earlier.
2. Why did the public focus on meat safety rather than worker safety? What does that tell you about Progressive-era priorities?
3. Identify ONE specific federal law passed within a year of publication.